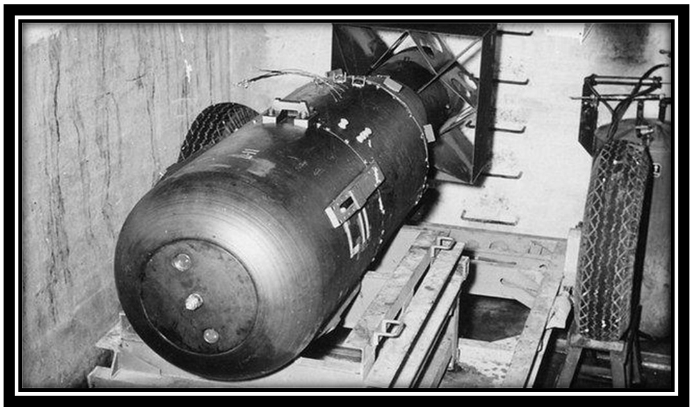
THERE’S A RECEIPT FOR THE “LITTLE BOY” BOMB THAT WAS DROPPED ON HIROSHIMA

A MULTI-SIGNED RECEIPT

566



The Hiroshima bomb was nicknamed 'Little Boy' - here it is before being loaded into the Enola Gay's bomb bay.

One of history's most important receipts is the one documenting the successful delivery and deployment of Little Boy , the atomic bomb dropped on Hiroshima during World War II. Following years of research and billions of dollars invested in its development, the bomb was transported across the Pacific and entrusted to American forces on Tinian. This handover led to the signing of a receipt that may be the most chilling, yet extraordinary, ever created.

THE MANHATTAN PROJECT

In the late 1930s, European physicists sent a letter to US President Franklin D. Roosevelt , warning him about atomic weapons research taking place in Germany. At that time, the United States had been conducting its own research on the subject, but on a much smaller scale.

The pace of research in the U.S. accelerated after Roosevelt received the Einstein–Szilárd letter and additional intelligence reports about Germany’s advancements. By 1942, the Manhattan Project was launched, transforming the ongoing atomic weapons research into a full-scale military program.

While the Manhattan Project is most famous for developing the atomic bomb, it also included a vast array of smaller programs focused on specific tasks. In fact, the majority of the project’s resources were dedicated to producing fissile material for the bombs. ***The total cost amounted to just under $2 billion.***

The Manhattan Project oversaw the development of two atomic bomb designs: the implosion-type, which used plutonium, and the gun type, which utilized uranium. Plutonium was easier to produce, but the implosion-type design was far more complex. Because confidence in its feasibility was limited, it became the only design to undergo testing before deployment. Meanwhile, the first completed gun-type bomb, *Little Boy,* used up all of the project’s uranium-235 supply, leaving no material for a test.

The Trinity Test on July 16, 1945, marked the first detonation of an atomic weapon and confirmed the implosion-type bomb’s success. On the same day, *Little Boy* was transported aboard the USS *Indianapolis* (CA-35), bound for Tinian. Due to the cargo’s extreme danger, its transfer required lots of documentation.

A RECEIPT WAS DRAWN UP FOR THE “LITTLE BOY” ATOMIC BOMB

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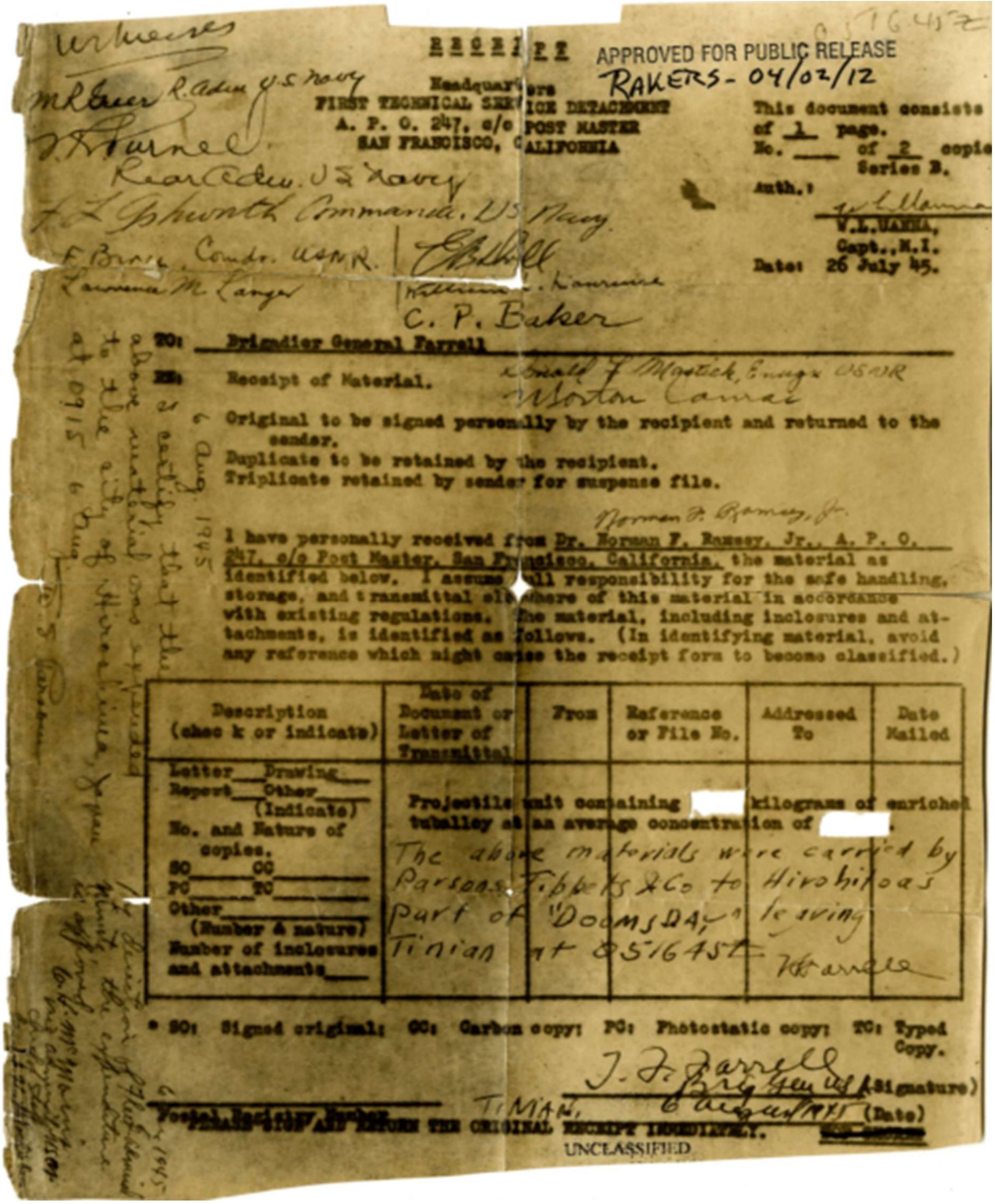

Witnesses

M. R. Greer R. Adm. U.S. Navy

W. R. Purnell

Rear Adm. U.S. Navy

F. L. Ashworth Commander, US Navy

E. Bruce, Comdr. USNR.

Lawrence M. Langer

William L. Laurence

C. P. Baker

051645Z

RECEIPT

Headquarters
FIRST TECHNICAL SERVICE DETACHMENT
A. P. O. 247, c/o POST MASTER
SAN FRANCISCO, CALIFORNIA

APPROVED FOR PUBLIC RELEASE
RAKERS - 04/02/12

This document consists of 1 page.
No. ___ of 2 copies
Series B.

Auth.: W. L. Uanna
W.L.UANNA,
Capt., M.I.

Date: 26 July 45.

TO: Brigadier General Farrell

RE: Receipt of Material.

Donald F. Mastick, Ensign USNR

Morton Camac

Original to be signed personally by the recipient and returned to the sender.
Duplicate to be retained by the recipient.
Triplicate retained by sender for suspense file.

Norman F. Ramsey, Jr.

I have personally received from Dr. Norman F. Ramsey, Jr., A. P. O. 247, c/o Post Master, San Francisco, California, the material as identified below. I assume full responsibility for the safe handling, storage, and transmittal elsewhere of this material in accordance with existing regulations. The material, including inclosures and attachments, is identified as follows. (In identifying material, avoid any reference which might cause the receipt form to become classified.)

Description (check or indicate)	Date of Document or Letter of Transmittal	From	Reference or File No.	Addressed To	Date Mailed
Letter___ Drawing___ Report___ Other___ (Indicate) No. and Nature of copies. SO___ CC___ PC___ TC___ Other___ (Number & nature) Number of inclosures and attachments___	Projectile unit containing [redacted] kilograms of enriched tuballoy at an average concentration of [redacted]. The above materials were carried by Parsons, Tibbets & Co to Hirohito as part of "Doomsday," leaving Tinian at 051645Z Farrell				

* SO: Signed original; CC: Carbon copy; PC: Photostatic copy; TC: Typed Copy.

T. F. Farrell
Brig Gen USA (Signature)

Tinian, 6 August 1945 (Date)

Postal Registry Number

PLEASE SIGN AND RETURN THE ORIGINAL RECEIPT IMMEDIATELY.

UNCLASSIFIED

6 Aug. 1945
I certify that the above material was delivered to the city of Hiroshima, Japan at 0915 6 Aug.
W. S. Parsons

6 Aug 1945
[illegible]

Mock-up of the receipt for Little Boy, the atomic bomb dropped on Hiroshima on August 6, 1945. (Photo Credit: U.S. National Archives)

One of the official pieces of documentation for the delivery of *Little Boy* is a tattered receipt , perhaps one of the most unique in history. It was signed by Thomas Ferrell, the Deputy Director of the Manhattan Project, to confirm the successful handover of much of *Little Boy*'s components from Dr. Norman F. Ramsey.

Ramsey left the US onboard the USS *Indianapolis*, which made the journey across the Pacific Ocean in just 10 days. After arriving in Tinian, Ramsey signed over *Little Boy* to Ferrell. ***However, the receipt wasn't just proof of the delivery of the atomic bomb - it also confirmed its use.***

Regardless of Hiroshima's destruction, the bureaucratic procedure required a piece of paper to confirm the use of the atomic bomb. To confirm this, Fleet Adm. Chester Nimitz's Chief of Staff signed the receipt, writing, "By direction of Fleet Admiral Nimitz, the expenditure of this item is approved."

Another signature on the receipt is that of William S. Parsons, the weaponeer onboard *Enola Gay* , the Boeing B-29 Superfortress that dropped *Little Boy* . He wrote , "I certify that the above materials was expended to the city of Hiroshima, Japan at 0915 6 Aug."

After it was signed, Ferrell kept hold of the atomic bomb's receipt and had crew members on Tinian sign it. For the rest of his life, he kept the historical document in his wallet, and it's now the only example of its kind known to exist. ***The receipt was donated to the US Army Heritage and Education Center in Carlisle, Pennsylvania by Ferrell's family, where it remains today.***

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